

After my life-long friend and lover died, at the age of twenty one, having decided that a death of quick and terrible violence was preferable to a life of slow and tortuous agony, I have failed to achieve a total state of peace. To escape from this pain I have strived to rise like foam in the troubled waves that roar beneath a storm; foam which even prefers the storm and wish that it may be tempestuous, not to reach greater heights but rather to increase their distance from the depths. For my age, I have achieved a certain degree of success in mundane affairs, or at least what I and a small circle of equally ignorant people might call success: a position in a prestigious university, a publication in a *Nature* journal, the respect of my peers and colleagues, the prospect of a good career... I have also distracted my mind and my body in sin and stupidity,